IAPSS MENA Platform

A simple guide to what the application does, who can do what, and how it is set up.

What it is	A website plus a private workspace for IAPSS MENA, the Middle East & North Africa branch of the International Association for Political Science Students.
Two parts	A public page anyone can read, and a members-only platform where approved members work in groups.
Built with	Next.js (website), Supabase (database, login, live chat), optional Claude API (chatbot), hosted on Vercel.

1. The idea in one minute

The platform solves two problems for IAPSS MENA: showing the world who the association is, and giving the team one place to organise its work.

- **Visitors** learn what IAPSS MENA is, what it is for, who is on the team, who it partners with and what projects it has led.
- **People who want to join** send a request. An admin decides whether they get in.
- **Approved members** are organised in groups, each with a leader. They share tasks, chat live and keep personal to-do lists.
- **A chatbot** answers questions about IAPSS, on the public page and inside the platform.

2. The public website

Anyone can open it without an account. It has these sections:

Section	What visitors see
Hero	A short statement of what IAPSS MENA is, plus a facts box (region, parent organisation, global network size).
About	What IAPSS MENA is and how it relates to IAPSS worldwide.
What it is for	Four purposes: academic dialogue, research and writing, mentorship, networking and outreach.
Our team	The people who run IAPSS MENA (managed by admins).
Our partnerships	Organisations the team works with (managed by admins).
Our projects	Initiatives the team has led (managed by admins).
Join	Sign in or request to join, with the three steps of the approval process.

> **Admin-managed content.** The team, partners and projects are not hard-coded. An admin adds or removes them in the dashboard page called **Site content**, and the public page updates immediately. Until something is added, the section shows a friendly "coming soon" message.

3. Joining and admin approval

Nobody enters the platform just by signing up. Every request is reviewed by an admin.

Step	What happens
1. Request	The person creates an account with their name, email and password.
2. Waiting	They see a "Waiting for approval" screen. They cannot see any platform data, only their own profile.
3. Review	An admin opens the **People** page. Pending requests are listed at the top, and the sidebar shows a count badge.
4. Decision	The admin clicks **Approve** or **Reject**. Approved people enter the platform. Rejected people see a short message.
Later	An admin can revoke access at any time, or promote a member to super admin.

The very first account ever created becomes the super admin and is approved automatically.

4. Roles: who can do what

Role	Can do
Super admin	Approve or reject join requests. Create and delete groups. Set each group's leader. Add or remove members. Create tasks anywhere. Change roles. Edit the public Site content.
Group leader (set per group)	Inside their own group only: add or remove members, create, assign and delete tasks.
Member	See their own groups, move the tasks assigned to them, chat, use their private to-do list.
Pending / rejected	See only a waiting or declined screen. No access to groups, tasks or chat.

These rules are enforced by the database itself (row-level security), not only by the screens. A member cannot reach data they are not allowed to see, even by trying.

5. Inside the platform

Overview

A welcome banner, four headline numbers (groups, open tasks, percentage completed, overdue), progress per group, and the list of tasks assigned to you.

Groups

A group is a team working on something, for example the Liaison team. Each group has exactly one leader and any number of members. Each group page has three tabs:

- **Task board:** a Kanban board with four columns: To do, In progress, Review, Done. Cards can be dragged between columns or moved with the small dropdown.
- **Chat:** a live channel only for that group.
- **Members:** who is in the group and who leads it. Admins and leaders add or remove people here.

Tasks and tracking

Each task has a title, description, assignee (chosen from the group's members), priority (low, medium, high) and an optional due date. Overdue tasks are highlighted in red.

The **Tasks** page gathers everything you are allowed to see in one table. You can filter by status, group, overdue, or only your own tasks. A side panel shows the workload of each person (tasks done out of tasks assigned). Progress bars on every group show how much is finished.

Live chat

Messages appear instantly for everyone in the channel, without refreshing. There is a **General** channel for all approved members and one private channel per group. Only members of a group can read its channel.

My to-do

A personal checklist for every user, with optional due dates and a progress bar. It is private: not even admins can see it.

People (admins only)

Approve or reject join requests, see everyone with their groups and status, revoke access, and switch someone between Member and Super admin.

Site content (admins only)

Add or remove the team members, partners and projects shown on the public page. Only confirmed facts should be entered here, because visitors can read them.

6. The chatbot

An "Ask IAPSS" button sits in the corner of every page. It answers short questions about the World Congress, Model UN, the Politikon journal, IAPSS MENA's activities and how to join. Inside the platform it also explains how groups, tasks and chat work.

Mode	How it works
Built-in (default)	Answers from a fixed knowledge base. Free, no key needed, but limited to the topics it knows.
Claude API (optional)	If an `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` is added, the answers come from Claude, restricted to the IAPSS facts supplied to it. This is a paid API, billed per message.

7. How it is built

Piece	Technology	Role
Website and app	Next.js 14, React, Tailwind CSS	All pages, the dashboard and the chatbot endpoint.
Database and login	Supabase (PostgreSQL + Auth)	Stores groups, tasks, messages, profiles and site content; handles sign-in.
Live updates	Supabase Realtime	Instant chat messages and task changes.
Permissions	Row-level security (SQL)	Enforces the roles above inside the database.
Hosting	Vercel	Publishes the site on the internet.

The project lives in `D:\iapss web site`. The database is set up by three SQL files in the `supabase` folder, run once in this order: `schema.sql`, `002_approval_and_content.sql`, `003_seed_site_content.sql`.

8. Going live

- In Supabase, turn **Confirm email** off. Admin approval replaces email checking, and this avoids the "email rate limit exceeded" error.
- Put the project in its own GitHub repository (the `.env.local` file with the keys is ignored and never uploaded).
- Import the repository in Vercel and add two environment variables: `NEXT_PUBLIC_SUPABASE_URL` and `NEXT_PUBLIC_SUPABASE_ANON_KEY` (the publishable key). Add `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` only if you want the Claude chatbot.
- In Supabase, under Authentication, URL Configuration, set the Site URL to the Vercel address.
- Never use the Supabase secret key (`sb_secret_...`) in this app.

9. Current limits

- English only. A French or Arabic version can be added.
- No one-to-one private messages yet, only the General channel and group channels.
- Members sign up themselves; admins cannot create accounts for people.
- Site content can be added and removed, but not edited in place (delete and re-add to change an entry).
- The facts about IAPSS MENA come from public sources and internal team files. Items such as the Policy Brief Competition and the contact email should be confirmed with the team before launch.